

COMMITTEE
MEMBERS'
PAPERS

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Lodge System of
Masonic
Education
Utah, 1961

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THE LODGE SYSTEM OF MASONIC EDUCATION

Prepared by
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on

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Interpretation of the Ritual of the Second Degree

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 1

You are now a Fellowcraft Mason. Because the Fellowcraft Degree chances to lie between the Entered Apprentice and Master Mason Degrees you must not permit yourself to fall into the error of considering it a half-way station, a mere transition from one to the other. It has in itself the same completeness, the same importance, as each of the other two, with a definite purpose of its own.

There are two great ideas embodied in the Fellowcraft Degree. They are not the only ideas in it, but if you understand them, they will lead you into an understanding of the others.

One of these is the idea of adulthood.

Whereas the Entered Apprentice represents youth standing at the portals of life, his eyes on the rising sun, the Fellowcraft is a man in the prime of life-experienced, strong, resourceful, able to bear the heat and burden of the day.

When he comes to experience adulthood, a man discovers that the mere fact that he is forty or fifty years of age has little to do with it. Adulthood is a condition, a state of life, a station charged with a set of duties.

What does the Second Degree have to say to the Fellowcraft, whether in Masonry or in the world at large? The answer to that brings us to our second idea. That idea is that the Fellowcraft may so equip himself that he will prove adequate to the tasks which will be laid upon him.

What is that equipment? The Degree gives us at least three answers. Let us ponder each of them a moment.

The first answer is that the Fellowcraft must gain direct experience from contact with the realities of existence. You will recall

what was said about the Five Senses. Needless to say, that portion of the Middle Chamber Lecture was not intended to be a disquisition on either physiology or psychology; it is symbolism and represents what a man learns through seeing, touching, tasting, hearing and smelling-in short, experience from year to year until, at last, through the very contacts of his senses with the objects which make up the world, he has come to understand that world, how to deal with it, how to master it at the point where he stands.

The second answer is education. After all, an individual's possible experience is extremely limited, circumscribed by the length of his Cable Tow. To our own store of hard-won experience, we must add the experience of others, supplementing our experience by the information of countless men brought to us by the knowledge taught us by the race and its teachers.

Consider the Apprentice in the days when Masons were builders of great and costly structures. He was a mere boy entirely ignorant of the secrets and arts of the builders; and yet, after seven years or so he was able to produce his master's piece and take his place at any task to which the Worshipful Master might appoint him. This was accomplished by teaching, by the Master Masons about him guiding his clumsy hands and passing on to him in many lessons what they had been years in acquiring.

Such is education. It is symbolized in the Second Degree by the Liberal Arts and Sciences. Perhaps you were somewhat non-plussed to hear what was said about grammar, rhetoric, logic, arithmetic, astronomy and music, and wondered what such school-room topics had to do with Masonry. You understand now. The explanation of these subjects was not meant to be an academic lecture out of a college course; like so much else in the Degree it was symbolism, and symbolism signifies all that is meant by education.

A Fellowcraft of life then must be equipped with experience and knowledge. Is there anything more? Yes, there is a third answer. That third answer is wisdom.

A man may see, hear, touch, and handle things so much that he wins a rich experience, and yet not have knowledge, he may have such knowledge, he may have mastered some task , or art, or trade, and yet be unhappy and a failure as a human being because he cannot adjust himself to the complex system of realities, experience and facts which make up life as a whole. He may lack wisdom- competency to deal with each situation that arises, it matters not what it may be.

The Middle Chamber, which is so conspicuous an element in the Second Degree doubtless has many meanings, but it most certainly has this-that it is a symbol of the wisdom of which I have just been speaking. Through the experience of the Five Senses, up through the knowledge gained of the Liberal Arts and Sciences, the candidate is called to advance, as on a Winding Stair, to that balanced wisdom of life in which the senses, emotions, intellect, character, work, deeds, habits and soul of a man are knit together in unity-balanced, poised, adequate.

This interpretation of the Fellowcraft Degree touches but the hem of its manifold meanings. It has been my purpose only to give you certain suggestions, and I hope that with them now in your possession you may be inspired to search out all the other meanings for yourself.

Symbols and Allegories of the Second Degree

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 2

In my brief talk I shall confine myself to those symbols and allegories that belong particularly to the Second Degree. Among the allegories peculiar to it, the most striking and important one is that rite in which you, as a candidate, acted the part of a man approaching King Solomon's Temple. You came into its outer precincts, passed between the two pillars, climbed a winding stair and at last, after passing through an outer and an inner door, entered its Middle Chamber. Standing in it you acted the part of a Fellowcraft workman who received his wages of Corn, Wine and Oil; and during certain stages of this allegorical journey you listened to various parts of a discourse which Masonry calls the Middle Chamber Lecture.

This entire acted allegory is a symbolic picture of the true and inner meaning of initiation. The Temple is the life into which a man is initiated. The stairs you climbed represented the steps by which the life of initiation is approached- qualification, petition, election and the Degrees. The Pillars represent birth; when you passed between them it signified that you were no longer a profane but had now entered the circle of initiates. The Middle Chamber represents initiation completed; once arrived there the candidate receives the rewards for the ordeals and arduous labors he has endured on the way; he has arrived at his goal.

The whole process of Masonic initiation is itself a symbolic allegory, so that in this central portion of the Degree we have an allegory within an allegory. We must ask then what is symbolized by Masonic initiation itself.

The answer is that it symbolizes, and in so doing interprets the experience of every man who seeks the good life; and by interpreting it teaches us how the good life is found.

Consider that form of the good life which we are seeking when we seek education or enlightenment. In the beginning man is a profane, stands in the outside darkness, is in that ignorance from which he would escape into the Inner Chamber of knowledge. How is he qualified? By having the necessary desire to learn and by possessing the required faculties and abilities. How does he find his way? By trusting to his guides, that is his teachers and books. He must feel his way along from stage to stage for he has never walked it before; it is an ascending path that is laborious, arduous, difficult, for there is no royal road to learning. What is the door through which he can enter? It is a door composed of the Two Pillars, which means birth; this signifies that knowledge must be won inside our natures; others may assist but their assistance is limited; each man must learn by his own efforts; knowledge is never permanently won until it is made a part of ourselves.

The value of enlightenment is represented by the Temple, set apart from the world of ignorance, won at the cost of great sacrifice.

The belief that the goods of life come by luck is a most fatal blunder. The satisfying goods of life, whether they be spiritual, moral, intellectual or physical, have a nature which renders it impossible for them ever to be won by luck. They cannot come at all except by our toiling to make them come and even then, they cannot come except at the cost of change and transformations in our own natures which are often painful and costly to make.

Such is the meaning of our allegorical entrance into King Solomon's Temple as a candidate in the Second Degree. You can see at once that all other symbols and allegories in the Degree are to be interpreted in the light of that meaning; that in the light of that meaning the Degree itself becomes a living power by which to shape and build our lives, not only in the Lodge-room itself but in the world of human experience of which the Lodge-room is a symbol.

Duties and Privileges of a Fellowcraft

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 3

The duties of a Fellowcraft are quickly described. His first and foremost duty is to live according to the obligations of the Degree; to be obedient to the officers of the Lodge and to the rules, regulations and laws of the Fraternity. Also, he must learn well the catechism in order to pass his test for proficiency, and it is expected that he will attend the Lodge when opened on his Degree as often as possible. If he be earnest and sincere, he will study to understand the meaning of the Degree as a preparation for his Masonic life.

His limitations are equally plain. He cannot sit in Lodge when opened on the Third Degree; he is not entitled to vote, to hold office, to have a voice in the business of the Lodge, or to enjoy such privileges of relief, burial, etc., as are reserved to Master Masons only.

As privileges or rights, he can visit or sit in any regular Lodge opened in the First or Second Degrees; he can ask to be coached and instructed and may counsel with well-informed Brethren; he can make himself known to other Fellowcrafts by means of his modes of recognition; and within the necessary limits he may enjoy the social fellowship of the Lodge.

But all this falls far short of what it means to be a Fellowcraft Mason.

First, a Mason remains a Fellowcraft in every respect, save in the legal sense, as long as he lives. To make this plain let me ask you to imagine the taking of the First Degree as being like the drawing of a circle; the Second Degree is a circle drawn around the outside of the first; the Third Degree is a still larger circle drawn around the other two, and containing them both. A portion of the whole of Freemasonry is contained within the first circle, another portion is in the second, a third portion is in the last. Or if you wish to describe it in another

manner, being a Master Mason includes within itself, and all at one stroke, being also an Apprentice Mason and a Fellowcraft Mason. The Apprentice and Fellowcraft Degrees are not like the stages left behind in a journey and, therefore, to be abandoned or forgotten, but rather they are taken up, preserved and incorporated in the Master Mason Degree.

To understand Freemasonry in its entirety, it is, therefore, as necessary for you to grasp it as it presents itself in the Second Degree as elsewhere.

In the Fellowcraft Degree we are put into possession of the Masonry of the mind.

In the Entered Apprentice Degree, we have the Masonry of conscience, where we are taught how necessary is obedience, apprenticeship and industriousness if we would become good men and true. In the Third Degree we have, as you will learn in due time the Masonry of the soul, in which the candidate learns the secret of the spiritual life. Running through all three Degrees we have the Masonry of the sentiments: fellowship, goodwill, kindness, affection, brotherly love, etc.

What is this Masonry of the Mind? It is the Masonry which has as its motto: "Let there be Light;" which declares ignorance to be one of the worst of misfortunes and one of the deadliest of enemies; which proclaims that enlightenment is one of the great goods of life; and which holds that a man must be a Mason in his head as well as in his heart.

That this is not an idle or fanciful picture is proved by the history of Freemasonry itself. It was established some six centuries ago by the Operative builders, who gave the world, among their other masterpieces, the great Gothic cathedrals of Europe. Their art was at once the highest and most difficult practiced in their period, and that art was built on what we now call science. Through all the changes of the Craft in after years, through its transformation two hundred years ago into a Speculative Fraternity, that great intellectual tradition of theirs has remained at the forefront, and stands today embodied in

the Second Degree, which exists to teach Masons to be lovers of the Liberal Arts and Sciences.

This Masonry of the mind is the inner essence and real meaning of the Second Degree; so that hereafter whenever as a Mason you prove yourself a friend of enlightenment, whenever you become a champion of the mind's right to be free, to do its work without check or hindrance, or become the enemy of bigotry or intolerance, support schools and colleges, and labor to translate into fact and action the motto: "Let there be Light," you will be living out in your life the teachings of the Fellowcraft Degree.

The Teachings of Masonry

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 4

Already you have discovered that Masonry's teaching is unlike that of the schools. This is not as easy to follow as the school-room method, but over that method it has this one great advantage: it makes a Mason study and learn for himself, forces him to search out the truth, compels him to take the initiative, as a grown man should, so that the very act of learning is in itself of great educational value. The purpose of secrecy is not to keep a candidate in the dark, but to stimulate him to seek the light; the symbols and emblems do not conceal the teaching, they reveal it; but they reveal it in such a manner than a man must find it for himself.

Freemasonry has three tenets, or great teachings; these are Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth.

Freemasonry is a Fraternity devoted to Brotherhood-but this Brotherhood must be understood in a special sense. Freemasonry's position is that Brotherhood rests on a religious basis; we are all Brothers, or should be, because God is the Father of us all; therefore, religion is one of the foundations of Masonry.

Masonry is dedicated to God, the Sovereign Grand Architect of the Universe. It keeps an Altar at the center of every Lodge-room and the Holy Bible lies open upon that Altar. It begins and ends its undertakings with prayer. _It~ petitioners must believe in God. All this is genuine religion, not a formal religiousness. But this religion of Masonry, like all else in its teaching, is not set forth in written creeds or in any other form of words; the Mason must come upon it for himself, and put it in such form as will satisfy his own mind.

Along with religion, Masonry teaches the necessity of morality, requiring of its members that they be good men and true, righteous when tried by the Square, upright when tried by the Plumb, their passions kept in due bounds by the Compasses, just in their dealings

with their fellows, patient with the erring, charitable, truthful, honorable.

Of the theological virtues of Faith, Hope and Charity our Craft says, as did the Apostle, that “the greatest of these is Charity,” and each of us must stand ready at any and all times privately to extend a helping hand in relief of an unfortunate Brother, or his dependents. Masonry, however, unlike some of the sects and cults, does not advocate a charity carried to the limits of fanaticism; there is such a thing as a Cable Tow, the extent of ability and opportunity, and we are not expected to give relief beyond the point where it would work damage to ourselves or hardship to our families.

Another of Masonry’s great teachings is Equality, symbolized by the Level. This does not represent that impossible doctrine which would erase all distinctions and holds that in all respects all men are the same, for it is evident that in many respects men are very unequal, as in physique, in talent, in gifts, in abilities, and in character; it is, rather, the principle that we owe good will, charity, tolerance and truthfulness equally to each and all, and that within our Fraternity all men travel the same road of initiation, take the same obligations, pay the same dues and have the same duties, rights and privileges.

A like importance is attached to the need for enlightenment. The motto of Masonry is: “Let there be Light.” and almost the whole of the Second Degree is a drama of education. There is a Masonry of the mind as well as of the heart and of the hand. To reverence the wise, to respect teachers, to value and uphold schools and to encourage the Liberal Arts and Sciences is one of our most ancient traditions.

Outside the Lodge-room the Mason is to be good citizen, loyal to his government, taking no part in broils and rebellions, conducting himself as a moral and wise man, remembering in all things that he has in his keeping the good name of the Fraternity.

These teachings arise out of the nature and needs of that Brotherhood for the sake of which the whole system of the Craft exists. To endure through all vicissitudes and to satisfy our natures, Brotherhood must have a spiritual basis, hence the all-importance of

our foundation of religion. Brotherhood requires that men must be held together by unbreakable ties, hence the necessity for morality which is a name for the forces that bind us in the relations of amity and accord. Difference of beliefs and opinions must not be permitted to rupture those bonds, hence the need for tolerance. Men cannot come together or remain together except they have the same rights and privileges, hence the necessity of equality. They cannot work together except they all understand the work to be done, hence the need for enlightenment. They will not be drawn together except they are filled with that spirit of good-will which necessarily expresses itself in charity and relief. And a Brotherhood itself cannot exist except in a society which admits it, hence the need for Masons to be good citizens. Through all the teachings of Masonry run these principles which lead back to its conception and practice of brotherhood. Gain a clear understanding of that and you will have that Royal Secret by which all else is made plain.

I have two suggestions to make to you, each of which, if you will adopt it, will be of inestimable value to you as you ponder the teachings of Masonry.

One of these is that you study carefully the Old Charges of a Freemason. These were the Charges given to the candidates by the old Operative Masons to define and explain the Masonic life; they were used for centuries and they continue to be a body of unwritten law in which every aspect of Masonry finds expression.

The other is that you study with equal care the following statement: "Masonry teaches man to practice charity and benevolence, to protect chastity, to respect the ties of blood and friendship, to adopt the principles and revere the ordinances of religion, to assist the feeble, guide the blind, raise up downtrodden, shelter the orphan, guard the altar, support the government, inculcate morality, promote learning, love man, fear God, implore His mercy and hope for happiness."

Masonic Education

Meeting No. 3

Subject No. 5

I hope you may not permit the word education to prejudice you against my subject. As we employ the word it refers to those means by which a Mason may learn what he needs and desires to learn about our Fraternity in order to understand and appreciate it and take a worthy part in it- a subject which stands at the center of the Second Degree and one for which we are sure you already have discovered the necessity.

The member of a golf club or a card club or a fishing or hunting club is not obliged to pass through a course of instruction to understand it.

Freemasonry is a different kind of organization. It is so different that it is not easy to think of any other society with which to compare it. Masonry is not an obvious and familiar thing a man already understands when he joins it, but it is rather something that must be learned. In order that this may be made more plain let us consider a few facts.

Masonry is so organized that a man cannot be admitted to it merely by paying a fee and signing a book. He must pass through a series of initiations which require of him that he study and learn much. It does not entice men in its membership by offering them pleasures and indulgences, but calls them, if they are properly qualified and have the motive, to the living of a certain kind of life.

What this life is it does not set forth in a few simple rules but bodies forth in a system of ritual and symbolism. This system cannot be understood in a few minutes. It calls for study, reflection, a vigorous application of the mind.

One of the peculiarities of Masonry is the place occupied by it in history. Our history which is very ancient, is interesting as such; but infinitely more than this it is a living and active part of our work, not

something dead and done with but vital and close to us. There is no dead hand of the past in Masonry; the hand of the past is alive, holds us in a strong grip, and shapes and determines much that we do. One cannot understand Masonry apart from its history.

Of like bearing is the fact that Masonry in one of its aspects exists as a system of laws. These laws are in the form of Ancient Landmarks, Old Charges, Constitutions, traditions, usages, edicts, laws, regulations, customs, By-laws, and authority vested in officers. Whatever is done in Masonry is done lawfully. The Craft is not like an open enclosure in which, after he has passed the barrier, every man is left free to do as he pleases; but rather it is like an organism in which each part and organ acts according to the law of the whole.

Consider also the offices in the Masonic system. They carry with them heavy responsibilities. The Worshipful Master, for example, is not simply a presiding officer, but is indeed and in truth a Master, the executive head of the Lodge, responsible for its welfare to the Grand Lodge. To qualify for such an office he must pass through a long apprenticeship in active work, serve as a Warden and he must learn thoroughly the ritual of all three Degrees as well as the opening and closing ceremonies and rules of order, to say nothing of the laws and practices.

If our form of organization is complex it is because our activities are many. Freemasonry is a world-wide Fraternity. Here in our country it has Lodges in almost every community. All these Lodges are busy constantly; together with their two and one-half million members, they make up a great world within the world. When a man becomes a Mason, it is this world he enters; consequently, if he is to take interest in his Masonry, he will wish to know something about all these activities.

As you enter this great world of Masonry you will not be content to look on from a distance, but he will be eager to enter into it, to take a part in its affairs, and to enjoy to the full the rich life that pulsates through it. What we describe as education is just the ways and means of doing so.

We recommend that, while learning the catechism of the three Degrees you learn thoroughly. As time passes you will find this to be a foundation upon which you can build a satisfying Masonic career; it will make it easier for you to take part in Lodge life, to visit other Lodges, perhaps to hold office, and at the same time it will be a possession for you within your own mind, from which you will constantly draw inspiration and light in your daily life.

We recommend that you attend Lodge as frequently and regularly as possible. One can best learn Masonry by practice, by actually engaging in it and of all the schools of the Craft the Lodge itself is the best. Moreover, in attending Lodge you will form those close associations with other Brethren that will in time ripen into enduring friendships- one of the great rewards of loyal service.

We recommend that as soon as you have become qualified or equipped, and as opportunities arise, you will stand willing to take an active part, not content with remaining on one side. This does not mean necessarily to hold office or to participate in the Degree work; the work of Masonry is far wider than that.

We recommend that you read a few books about the Craft, especially some brief but reliable history and a volume or two on our ritual and teachings. A few hours spent with such books will prove an investment of great value in the future.

We are confident that this description of the task of being a Mason will neither depress nor discourage you, but rather will be an inspiration to you, a challenge to your best endeavors, a proof to you of the richness and value of that life with us into which you are now entering.

